

expectoration. 'Tis used outwardly in baths for the womb, and the itch." Catnip has an excitatory effect on cats.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Catnip settles the stomach, is sedative and, as it stimulates sweating, reduces fever. The herb's pleasant taste and gentle action make it suitable for colds, flu, and fever in children, especially when mixed with elderflower (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132) and sweetened with honey. Catnip is markedly antifatulent, helping to settle indigestion and colic. The herb is also useful in treating headaches related to digestive problems. A tincture is beneficial as a friction rub for rheumatism and arthritis.

Self-help Use Digestive infections, p. 305.

Nicotiana tabacum (Solanaceae) Tobacco

Description Annual or biennial plant growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has an erect stem, large oval leaves, and pink or white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Tobacco is native to tropical America. It is now grown worldwide, chiefly for smoking tobacco but also as the source of an insecticide. Leaves for smoking are gathered, dried, and cured.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Tobacco contains alkaloids (notably nicotine) and a volatile oil. Nicotine is stimulant and addictive.

History & Folklore Even in 17th-century England, opinions on smoking were sharply divided. King James I unsuccessfully tried to ban "a custome loathsome to the eye, hatefull to the nose, harmfull to the braine [and] dangerous to the lungs." In Central America, tobacco was prescribed by the Maya as a treatment for asthma, convulsions, and skin disease. Tobacco has been used as part of rituals in many Native American cultures.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Tobacco is no longer used medicinally. The dried leaves make a good insecticide, but external application should be avoided as nicotine is readily absorbed through the skin.

Caution Tobacco should not be taken in any form.

Nigella sativa (Ranunculaceae) Black Cumin

Description Annual herb growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has an upright branching stem, fine deeply cut leaves, gray-blue flowers, and toothed seedpods.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to western Asia, black cumin is grown throughout much

of Asia and the Mediterranean region for its seeds and as a garden plant. The seeds are gathered once they are ripe.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents The seeds contain 40% fixed oil, a saponin (melantin), alkaloids, and up to 1.4% volatile oil.

History & Folklore Black cumin was found in the tomb of Tutankhamun, but its role in ancient Egypt, medicinal or otherwise, is unknown. Dioscorides, a Greek physician of the 1st century CE, recorded that black cumin seeds were taken to treat headaches, nasal congestion, toothache, and intestinal worms, and, in large quantities, as a diuretic, to promote menstrual periods, and to increase breast-milk production.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Like many culinary herbs, black cumin seeds are beneficial for the digestive system, soothing stomach pain and spasms and easing gas, bloating, and colic. The seeds are also antiseptic and are used to treat intestinal worms, especially in children. Cumin seeds are much used in India to increase the production of breast milk.

Research Recent research indicates that black cumin seed may prove useful in metabolic syndrome, a condition that typically involves raised cholesterol levels, raised blood pressure, and type 2 diabetes. The seeds are also antiviral and show promise in the treatment of chronic viral infections, such as hepatitis C.

Caution Love-in-a-mist (*N. damascena*) should not be used as a substitute for black cumin seeds.

Notopterygium incisum (Apiaceae)

Notopterygium Root, Qiang Huo (Chinese)

Description Carrot-family member with an upright ridged stem, deeply cut leaves, and flowers in dense clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Notopterygium root is native to central and western China. The root is unearthed in spring or autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Notopterygium root contains furanocoumarins, sterols, and a volatile oil.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Notopterygium root is taken mainly for colds and chills, fevers, headache, general aches and pains, and malaise. The herb is warming and pungent, counters cold and damp conditions, and promotes sweating, especially in fevers. It is also prescribed for neck and back pain.

Caution At high dosage notopterygium root may cause vomiting.

Nymphaea alba (Nymphaeaceae) White Water Lily

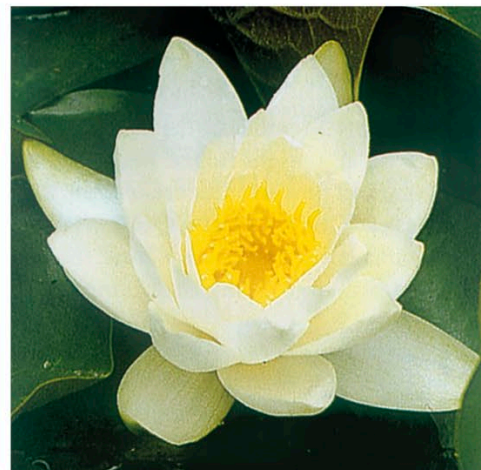
Description Perennial aquatic plant with deep roots, plate-shaped leaves on long cylindrical stems, and large-petaled white flowers occasionally tinged with pink.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, white water lily is found in ponds and in still water in lakes, rivers, and canals. The rhizome is gathered in autumn.

Parts Used Rhizome, flowers.

Constituents The rhizome contains alkaloids (nymphaeine and nupharine), resin, glycosides, and tannins.

History & Folklore According to the 17th-century herbalist Nicholas Culpeper, "The leaves do cool all inflammations ... the syrup helpeth much to procure rest, and to settle the brains of frantic persons."



White water lily flowers have a sedative effect, calming nervous tension and anxiety.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The rhizome of the white water lily is astringent and antiseptic. A decoction treats dysentery, or diarrhea due to irritable bowel syndrome. White water lily has also been employed to treat chronic bronchitis and kidney pain, and taken as a gargle for sore throats. The rhizome may be used to make a douche for vaginal soreness and discharge, or to make a poultice for boils and abscesses. White water lily flowers have long been reputed to reduce sexual drive. Their generally calming and sedative effect on the nervous system makes them useful in the treatment of insomnia, anxiety, and similar disorders of this nature.

Research Studies suggest that white water lily may, as has been claimed, act as an anaphrodisiac, diminishing sexual drive. The plant has been found to lower blood pressure in animals.

Related Species The white pond lily (*N. odorata*) is a close American relative used for much the same purposes. The rhizome of the white lotus (*N. lotus*),